Paradise, Kansas

By Cathleen Sakamai

SHE: (Pg 3-7) He got this for me a couple of years ago, when I was 14. *(shows a rubber bracelet on her wrist)* It says, "Different is OK! and it's rainbow, and I loved rainbows. But the kids at school didn't really love rainbows and suddenly they had new, colorful names to call me. But I came home and said to my brother, "I'm different, yeah, but I'm not a lesbian. I mean, I don't think I am." And my older brother, Jack, he said it was the only one they had, and he didn't think I was gay, but he wanted to get it for me because of the words. . .but . . .

Different is not okay in Testament, Kansas. Population: 4,000. Testament, Kansas, where the cows and chickens far outnumber the people and the wheat fields aren't just a stereotype -- they're a reality, like this sea of waving golden brown that just stretches out forever. And we have lots of sorghum, soybeans and corn too, but they're not nearly as notorious as the wheat.

I was born with a really intense wheat allergy, which I like to think is this really romantic but perverse analogy for being born here, ***being here***. And I remember thinking that if I could just put a finger on it, it would make it easier, actually. That if I was gay or a child prodigy or deaf or something, that the difference would suddenly make sense and I'd get it. But I wasn't any of those things and neither was Jack. Instead we were these people that didn't make sense to anyone around us. And that feels foreign to a kid.

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INTRODUCTION

In a small Kansas town where difference is something to survive rather than celebrate, a young girl watches her beloved brother Jack slowly disappear. What begins as a desperate search for belonging transforms into something darker as her brother is pulled toward extremist ideology and the seductive promise of purpose.

Religious radicalization does not arrive all at once; it seeps quietly into the cracks of loneliness and loss of identity.

Paradise, Kansas by Cathleen Sakamai is a story about grief, manipulation, and the devastating cost of losing someone to an idea that convinces them hatred is holy.

SHE: Teenagers here don't talk about politics or human rights or religious freedom. They talk about McCab's field on Friday night or taking over their parents' business after high school. And saying that makes me sound like some kind of elitist -- and I'm not. I've been called that since before I understood what it really meant. And Jack would say, "maybe it's not that we're too good for Testament. Maybe Testament is too good for us." Which was like a riddle with no answer that was too big to even think about. Kids aren't supposed to have existential crises, right?

So, Jack would drive us to Topeka for art festivals and films and to hear people speak and things of that sort. And okay, so, you're laughing, "Wow, Topeka;" but, for me, it was proof. You know? Proof that there were people out there who had different ideas and could talk about them and engage. And Jack would tell me that we were going to get out of Testament and meet people who ***got us*** and that there was just so much out there. And as long as I had him, I was okay. I really was.

He drove us once, late on a Sunday night, about two hours from home out into the middle of nowhere. And we pulled into a 7-11and he came back with two lime ice bars, handed me one of them and said, "Well, you've been saying for years that you wanted to come here. Here we are." And I said, "What are you talking about?" And Jack said, "Welcome to Paris. . . Kansas. Isn't it amazing?" And it was ***not*** very amazing; but he was so pleased with himself, we took a selfie with the town sign. Population 371. And then we talked about going to the ***actual*** Paris someday.

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And I closed my eyes. And I believed.

Jack found out about a year after that. The spring of his senior year. He'd applied to a bunch of really good schools. He had good grades and all of that, and, well, he didn't get into any of the schools. Not one. And he just kept saying that it was fine, and I kept saying that it wasn't. It wasn't fine at all. But he wasn't going to leave to go to school in ***Kansas*** He would just stick it out, since I only had two more years, and then would we leave together. And secretly, I **was** relieved, you know? I was. And I should have pushed harder. But it's easy to be selfish, and you don't even realize it. It's as natural as breathing.

And so Jack just existed for a while. I don't know how else to put it. Maybe school and routine had kept him attached to something, and now he was just floating. I just wanted him to ***do*** something. To ***be*** something. He told me, "I don't belong." And I told him that this was not some kind of revelation. We never belonged. This wasn't new. But he was distant. Hours on-line in the basement. Quiet. Away. I should have done something. Acting is hard when you don't know what it is that you're trying to fight against. I said, *"I know you, Jack. I know you."* And he said, "Maybe." Really. . . maybe?

But here's the crazy part. He got better. He got a job at an auto-shop in Topeka. And at first I thought we'd really got on the train to Crazytown, right? This is my brother who wanted to go to law school and become an environmental attorney and he's painting people's cars. And then I thought, "Okay, so maybe I am elitist," and I've got to keep this in check because he was happy. And so I was happy too. And he introduced me to his friends, and there was so much laughter. I guess maybe camaraderie would be the way to put it. They laughed about our red hair. They said in their country, in Syria, it was called "crusader hair." And I said I liked that much better than being called Wendy or Pippi Longstocking. And they laughed. And Jack belonged.

Jack was staying most nights in Topeka with his friends, but he had come home for

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dinner on Sunday. He was buttering a roll when he told us that he was converting. And the quiet was so immense that the room suddenly felt very small. My dad took a bite of pot roast, and my mother got up to get something from the kitchen. The silence was probably worse than anything they could have said. But Jack was just excited, just babbling, and I couldn't figure out the right thing amongst all the things in my head. I thought, *I don't understand.* I thought, *I want you to belong and to be happy.* I thought, *Different is OK.* But I didn't say any of those things. I said, *"I love you."* And it sounded so young and foolish.

The worst part of it for me is the guilt, I think. This guilt of not saying or doing the right thing in a hundred or a thousand different moments. As if I could have that power to bring him back to me. Jack was very busy with learning and training, and I remember thinking that this idea of becoming Muslim – converting -- was a full-time job in itself. We did not see each other and we talked on the phone less and less. It became mostly Facebook messages between Jack and I, and those became less . . . coherent. Mostly him encouraging me to stay strong. And asking me to believe in him. I wanted to. I didn't know what I was believing.

He sent mom a message asking for her blessing and talking about the crusade. And then Jack was gone. I spent hours reading everything I could and sending messages. The auto-shop in Topeka had closed and a man sent me a message saying that Jack was a crusader. And we learned that Jack wasn't in the US anymore. We learned that he wasn't supposed to be communicating with us.

Last November, I got a message from Jack on Facebook. It was just a few words, *"I wish you could go with me. I hope to see you in Paradise."*

On November 13, 130 people died in the attacks in Paris. Jack posted a selfie with a group of men I did not know in front of the Eiffel Tower that morning. I will never go to Paris with my brother, Jack. There is no Paradise. That's a lie. And sometimes. . . sometimes. . . *(struggles to remove the rubber bracelet from her wrist)* different is ***not*** OK.

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Hate has its own kind of speed. On November 14, I drove to Topeka, to the mosque there, the ***majid***. And there were many people there, a crowd, swelling in the hate, the ugliness. And I was foreign to myself then, as I stood amongst the people holding their signs, yelling. I don't know what I wanted, but a woman in a ***hijab*** stepped past me and I clutched at her arm. It was my mouth, but it was not my voice: *"What did you people do to my brother?"*

And I cried, and I thought I would never stop. I was afraid that the hatred would eat me from the inside. The woman's name was Afan. She lost her aunt and uncle in Paris. They were Syrian refugees living in France. She told me that she understood.

I don't understand how to reconcile this pain of being. I will never see my brother, Jack, again. And I will never be the same. Afnan forgave, but I don't know how. I don't know how to understand when there is so much that is senseless. But I want to be ***different***, and I want to be ***OK***.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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